support for (ii) strategy development, (iii) roadmap development, and (iv) mapping of required support resources, as well as provide (v) detailed advice on access to funding from EU, national, and regional sources to allow the HEIs to deliver on the transformations; this should in particular include support and access to financial instruments for excellent research and innovation capacity, and support for disruptive innovation from academic sector, incl. spin-offs from universities and public research organisations, and cooperation agreements between academic and business sector. This should lead to a standard methodology to develop specific investment agendas for individual institutions or networks of HEI that consists of different funding and financial instrument branches, aligned with the priorities and areas of the common transformation agenda, and realising concerted support to the institutional transformation efforts universities want to engage in.

The acceleration services should be piloted together with large user groups (either individual HEI, networks or alliances of universities and surrounding ecosystem actors, or umbrella organisations of HEI), and progress of the users in the implementation of the chosen areas of the transformation agenda should be measured. Actions should therefore include an evaluation mechanism that enables to assess the strategies from individual HEIs or alliances of universities, pursuing institutional transformation towards universities of the future, for instance under supervision of an 'acceleration board' of independent experts. The evaluation mechanism should also monitor progress of the HEIs in the implementation of the chosen areas from the transformation agenda.

Projects should disseminate widely the methodology and the results of the pilot with user groups, as well as provide policy recommendations to the Commission and Member States on the acceleration services, in view of future targeted and synergetic actions in support of Higher Education sector.

The duration of the action should not exceed 5 years.

SCIENCE COMMUNICATION
Proposals are invited against the following topic(s):

HORIZON-WIDERA-2022-ERA-01-60: A European competence centre for science communication

Specific conditions	
Expected EU contribution per project	The Commission estimates that an EU contribution of around EUR 3.00 million would allow these outcomes to be addressed appropriately. Nonetheless, this does not preclude submission and selection of a proposal requesting different amounts.
Indicative budget	The total indicative budget for the topic is EUR 3.00 million.
Type of Action	Coordination and Support Actions

Expected Outcome: Projects are expected to contribute to the following expected outcomes:

- Consolidation of knowledge and development of guidelines, tools, innovative strategies, and recommendations to improve science communication for all research and innovation actors;

- Establishment of a European competence centre for science communication, sustained beyond the lifetime of funding;

- Increased networking and mutual learning, higher quality, more trustworthy, and more rapidly mobilised science communication by national authorities, businesses, civil society organisations, other stakeholders and projects.

Scope: Science communication is a scientific discipline, an activity conducted by career scientists and science outreach organisations, and a specific career pathway followed by journalists. It has the potential to improve science-society relations by increasing the transparency of science, building trust in the processes and outcomes of science, and raising scientific literacy. It can also improve the uptake of science by society and support evidence-based policy making.

Science and science communication have been undergoing radical changes over recent years, creating opportunities that may, in turn, pose new challenges. For instance, traditional media are increasingly being superseded by social media with more user-edited content; rapid diffusion of open access or pre-peer review papers gives the general public access to research that was previously locked behind paywalls; and open data enable a wider set of actors to interact with, analyse and interpret research results than in the past.

The covid-19 pandemic has highlighted the importance of communicating scientific knowledge and recommendations to respond to a fast-moving and critical threat. It is important to learn from this and other experiences when science communication has been essential to conveying scientific knowledge and recommendations on critical issues, to explaining how hypotheses, experiments and uncertainties are also part of the scientific method, to build capacities and strengthen networks, and to ensure greater ability in the future to react rapidly and effectively to critical situations.

This action has two parts, both of which must be addressed:

The first part consists of consolidating the evidence base on science communication from on-going and past projects and initiatives[93], covering a wide range of existing and potential critical areas for research and innovation for society. Particular attention should be paid to contextual issues (geography, gender, age, socio-economic status, etc.) that affect the uptake or effectiveness of science communication. Policy reports and recommendations, guidelines, and innovative strategies should be developed for all research and innovation actor types; potential targets should include government agencies and public authorities, research funding and performing organisations, and civil society organisations. An important outcome should

[93] In particular, but not limited to, projects supported by Horizon 2020's SwafS-19-2018-2019-2020 topic, but other relevant projects and initiatives within and outside the Framework Programmes should also be considered.